



The Other Half of the Song

Student copy (project or hand out)

1 Peabo Bryson, who died this week at seventy-five, had one of the great voices of his time, and he spent it, more often than not, making room for another. He was a soloist by gift and a partner by instinct. The songs the world kept were the ones he sang with someone beside him.

2 You know the songs even if you have let the name slip. The ballroom melody from 'Beauty and the Beast', the one he sang with Celine Dion. The carpet ride from Aladdin, 'A Whole New World', the one he sang with Regina Belle, which climbed to the top of the pop chart, the first song from an animated film ever to do it. Before those, the slow turn of 'Tonight, I Celebrate My Love', beside Roberta Flack. Three of the songs that made his name were three songs he gave away half of.

3 This is not to slight the solo work. There was plenty of it, going back to a teenager singing in Greenville and a first hit before he was thirty. His voice alone could fill a room, warm and unhurried and sure of the note before he reached it. But a voice like that can crowd a duet, can win it, can leave the other singer sounding small. His never did. He sang with people, not over them. That is harder than singing alone, and rarer, and he made it sound like the easiest thing in the world.

4 There is a kind of talent that needs to be the only light in the room. His was the other kind. To sing a duet well is to listen as much as to sound, to bend your own gift toward someone else's and let the blend be the point. He did that for the better part of his life, and the proof is in the recordings: two voices, and no seam where they meet.

5 He won two Grammys, both for duets, which feels exactly right. He could have chased the solo spotlight and the bigger name that comes with it. He reached instead for the harmonized line, the shared credit, the song that needed two people to be itself. It was the humbler choice and the better one, and it is why the songs have outlived the charts.

6 The voice is on the records now, where it will go on doing the thing it did best, which was to make whoever stood beside him sound like the only other person in the world. A soloist is mourned by his listeners. A duet partner is mourned by the voice that has lost its other half. Peabo Bryson leaves a great many of both. Rest him gently.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. Which of the following best characterizes the central claim the writer makes about Bryson's career?
 - A) that what most deserves honor is his choice to share songs, not the solo talent that would have let him dominate them
 - B) that his solo recordings were the true measure of his gift and the duets a distraction
 - C) that his duets worked only because his partners were more famous than he was
 - D) that he went underrated because he so rarely recorded on his own
2. The writer's attitude toward Bryson across the piece is best described as
 - A) fond but quietly critical of the choices that cost him greater fame
 - B) detached and evenhanded, weighing his strengths against his flaws
 - C) admiring, with the admiration aimed less at his talent than at his restraint
 - D) grieving to the point of treating his death as a national catastrophe

Discussion questions:

1. The writer claims that singing a good duet 'is harder than singing alone, and rarer.' How convincing is that claim as the piece makes it? What supports it, and what would you want added?
2. The piece dwells on the songs Bryson shared more than on his solo career. What does that choice tell you about what the writer wants the reader to value, and is anything lost by it?

Writing prompt (in-class or homework, Q2 rhetorical analysis):

Write an essay analyzing the rhetorical choices the writer uses to honor Peabo Bryson. Consider how antithesis (the soloist set against the partner), understatement and restraint, the handling of concrete detail (the named songs and partners), and the closing benediction work together to shape the tribute.